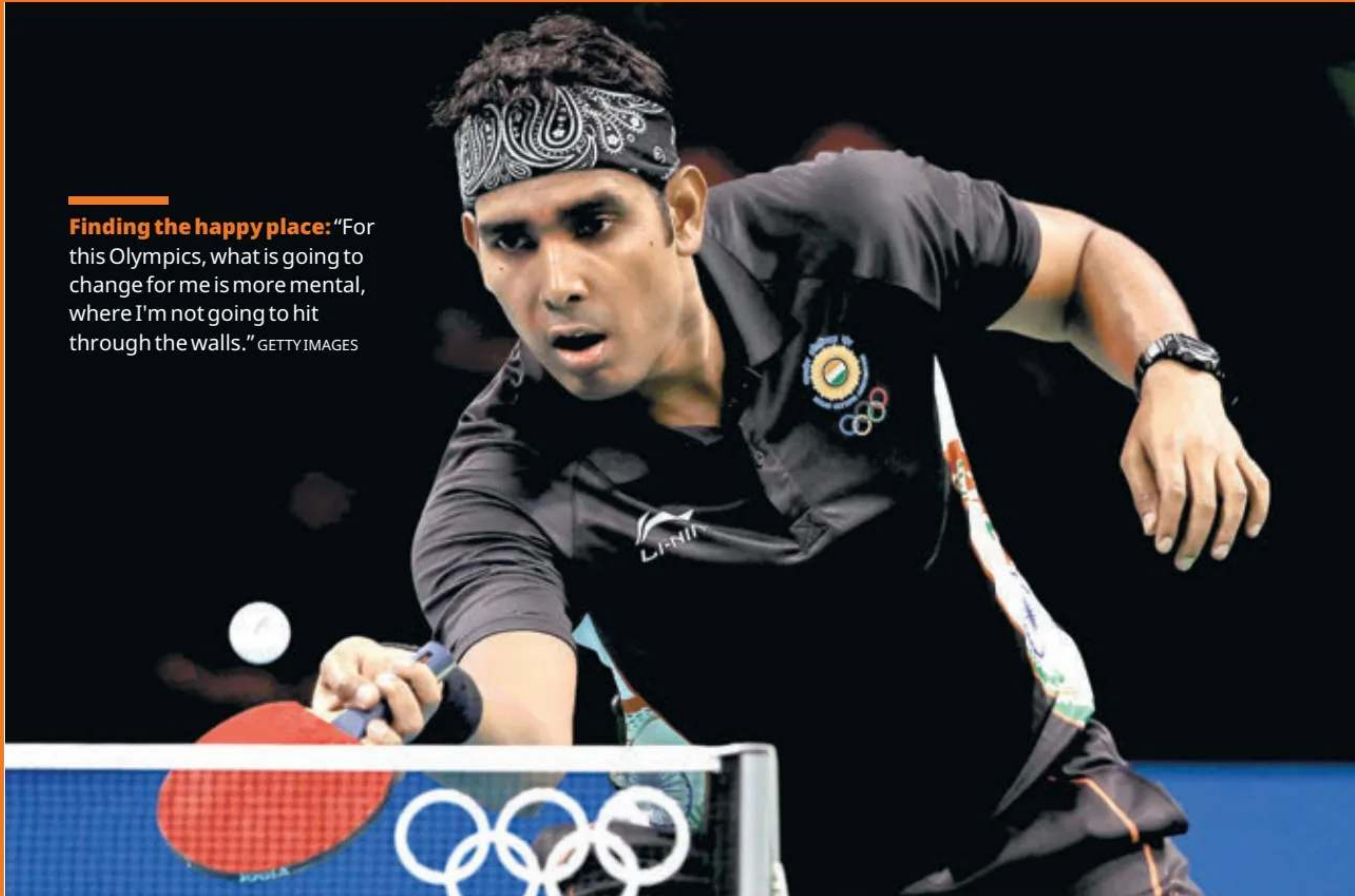


Finding the happy place: "For this Olympics, what is going to change for me is more mental, where I'm not going to hit through the walls." GETTY IMAGES



very tough for the opponent to find solutions.

How do you see the wins at this stage of your career in comparison to those when you had just started playing professionally? Do you value the former more?

More than me, society values it more. They give more respect: "Oh! He is 41 years old, and he's still doing it." If I did this in my 20s, is it not good enough? It's still a good performance.

It's a little bit tough to also compare your younger self when you don't hit that kind of stardom to now when you are older and get this kind of attention. Let's say if the same run had happened at Singapore Smash when I was 20, we would not be talking so much about it. We would have spoken about it for a week or something and moved on. Now, because of social media and society, there's a lot more awareness about sports and about what you're doing.

I won the Commonwealth gold in 2006 as well as in 2022. In 2006, people were still asking what I was studying because academics were important. In 2022, it was, "How do you still play?"

So, it is more of a perception, but what you can constantly see is that Indian sport is developing rapidly, going higher, and involvement in sports science is much higher, and that is the reason why all of us can prolong our careers.

I wanted to quit after the Rio Olympics when I was 34. Back then, or even now, at 34, you feel old. You feel like a fossil fuel. In the first round of the Singapore Smash qualifiers, I played against an 18-year-old. In the second round, I played a 23-year-old. In the third round, I played a 26-year-old. In the first round of the main draw, I faced a 22-year-old. Darko Jorgic is 25. The oldest opponent I faced was Omar Assar, who is 32.

And then Felix Lebrun is 17-years-old. My wife says, "You lost

to somebody who's just slightly older than our daughter."

So, back when I was young, I needed to have discipline and single-mindedness. I had to focus and run through it, and I ran through it even until the Tokyo Olympics. You just go through the wall, make sure everything works for you, and push yourself through that.

For this Olympics, what is going to change for me is more mental, where I'm not going to hit through the wall. I'm going to push myself physically, but I also have some deviations. Not distractions, but deviations. In terms of spending a little bit more time with family, or if I want to have a meal with a friend, I will do that. Back then, I would not go to any social gatherings. I have spent a lot of years doing that. We also want to enjoy a little bit of life. So, when I'm able to have that mental space, I think Singapore Smash can happen again.

You mentioned that you wanted